

SENATE No. 2647

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

SENATE, October 23, 2025.

The committee on Housing to whom was referred the petition (accompanied by bill, Senate, No. 964) of John J. Cronin, Patricia D. Jehlen, Mike Connolly and Manny Cruz for legislation to study single-stair residential buildings, report the accompanying bill (Senate, No. 2647).

For the committee,
Julian Cyr

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An Act to study single-stair residential buildings.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 (a) Notwithstanding any general or special law to the contrary, there shall be a special
2 commission to study and define conditions under which multi-family residential buildings up to
3 six stories in height may be built with a single-staircase. The commission shall produce a report
4 that includes a proposed building code amendment for consideration by the board of building
5 regulations and standards that would allow single-stair multi-family residential buildings of up to
6 six stories, including measures for mitigating any adverse health and safety impacts unique to
7 single-stair multi-family residential buildings.

8 (b) The commission shall consist of the commissioner of the division of occupational
9 licensure or their designee, who shall serve as chair, the house and senate chairs of the joint
10 committee on housing or their designees, the house and senate chairs of the joint committee on
11 public safety and homeland security or their designees, and the following members who shall be
12 appointed by the chair: 1 member representing the Fire Chiefs Association of Massachusetts, 2
13 members of the American Institute of Architects, 1 member who is a practicing fire engineer
14 representing the National Fire Protection Association, 2 members representing the Board of

15 Building Regulations and Standards, 1 member representing the American Planning Association
16 Massachusetts Chapter, 1 member representing the Home Builders and Remodelers Association,
17 1 member representing the Commercial Real Estate Development Association, 1 member
18 representing the Center for Building in North America, 1 member representing a building official
19 employed by a municipality with a Class 1 Fire Department and 1 member representing
20 Abundant Housing Massachusetts.

21 (c) The commission shall consider the report Legalizing Mid-Rise Single-Stair Housing
22 in Massachusetts produced by the Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies, Boston Indicators,
23 and Utile. The report shall include, but not be limited to, a technical study into the safety of
24 single-stair residential buildings compared to two-staircase buildings, proposed alternate safety
25 modifications to compensate for the staircase reduction, the proposed building code amendment
26 described in subsection (a), the estimated number of additional housing units that would result
27 from said amendment and proposed timeline and process by which the amendment may be
28 implemented. The report shall be submitted to the house and senate clerks, house and senate
29 committees on ways and means, the joint committee on housing and the joint committee on
30 public safety and homeland security by December 15, 2026.